

Project Title: The Greener Campus Initiative: Daring the Polyethene Challenge through Eco-friendly Shopping Alternatives

Brief outline of the project

Description of situation/ overall vision: Uganda Martyrs University (UMU)'s main campus, at Nkozi, is known for being a clean and green. UMU is green on account of; 1. the serene, greenery, and well-maintained and diversely planted compound; and 2. the care given to waste management on campus. On the contrary, her neighbouring urban communities stand out as hallmarks of irresponsible waste disposal, generated through massive use of single-use polythene bags by both business owners and residents. The current 'green compass' status, locally-attributed to UMU is undermined by the unabated generation of ecologically dangerous inorganic waste, and it can be enhanced by UMU's positive influence on the University community and the neighbouring urban communities. Through livelihoods and agricultural improvement programs, UMU positively influenced and continues to influence communities near and far, it is our desire that this as well happens in the area of protecting local ecosystems from excessive generation of inorganic waste. UMU can be 'greener' if it succeeds in managing waste better, internally, as well as influencing surrounding communities to embrace eco-friendly shopping options. The current status of UMU as a green campus is being undermined by the current lack of positive influence in the neighbouring communities in the area of waste management. This can be achieved through the enhanced practice of the 'Reduce, Re-use and Recycles principles', directed towards shopping material. This is important because much of the waste from businesses and residential areas, does not only constitute high amounts of polythene and plastic material, but it also ends up in swamps at the edges of the townships, roads and farmscapes; subsequently washed into river Katonga and lake Victoria. Through this project, efforts are made to encounter environmental degradation associated with increased use of single-use shopping polythene bags.

Background: Over 600 tonnes of plastics waste are generated every day in Uganda (Uganda Biodiversity Fund, 2021; Mubatsi, 2022). Majority of these are single-use plastic bags, generated by urban population and irresponsibly littered in urban spaces. These mostly end up in sensitive and vulnerable ecological zones and in slummy neighbourhoods. This is very true with urban centres near lakes, rivers and swamps like Kayabwe Town council, and in the neighbourhoods of Uganda Martyrs University. This worry is founded on the realization that more than 75% of used plastic bottles and polythene bags in Uganda end up in landfills, lakes, and rivers, with a serious environmental damage (Mubatsi, 2022). At local level, the swamps and cultivation areas near in and around Kayabwe town council are evidently infested with used polythene material and plastic bottles. The School of Arts and Social Sciences, offers a Bachelor of Fashion and Textile Design (BAFT), whose students have not only showed competence and willingness to make durable, but inexpensive shopping bags, but they have centrally supported this initiative.

Main objective: To foster Eco-friendly (environmental protection responsiveness) shopping behaviour through awareness creation and promotion of reusable alternatives to single-use shopping polythene bags.

Specific objectives:

a. To raise environmental protection consciousness

- b. To foster Eco-friendly shopping behaviour through provision of clothe shopping bags.

Pictures



Figure 1: The poster adverting the launch/ training for awareness creation.



Figure 2: The overlock sewing machine, which had not been budgeted for but was necessary.



Figure 3: The overlock sewing machine



Figure 4: One of the 4 students of fashion and design helping with the project.



Figure 5: Two of the 4 students of fashion and design using the two sewing machines bought for the project.



Figure 6: Some of the bags (work-in-progress)



Figure 7: The Academic Registry of UMU (Dr. Josef B. Buchana) presiding over the launch of the project, on behalf of the Vice Chancellor.





Figure 8: The project Implementer (Benedicto Kabiito) delivering the public lecture at Uganda Martyrs University (UMU)



Figure 9: Some physical participants of public lecture at Uganda Martyrs University (UMU)

